Trump's farmer bailouts are a day late, a dollar short

送信者: EG US Daily 受信日時: 2026-10-22 00:49

【メール原文】

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21 Oct 2026 11:46 EDT Discover more on the Portal

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Democratic midterm sweep would bring limited policy changes
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Netanyahu's plans won't lead to pre-midterm escalation

Trump’s farmer bailouts are a day late, a dollar short. President Donald Trump announced a new Harvest Fuel Relief program on Monday while at a rally for incumbent Senator Roger Marshall (R-KS). Sen. Marshall is in a tightly contested race against Democrat challenger Adam Hamilton which may prove decisive in the midterms.

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The program is intended to deliver $8 billion in direct payments to farmers struggling with high input costs for fertilizer and fuel, as well as existing cost pressures driven by falling exports. In agriculture-intensive states like Kansas and Iowa, Democrats have had success gaining support in traditionally Republican-leaning constituencies.
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As with prior promises during the election cycle, the future of these payments is uncertain – Trump explicitly conditioned the funding on a Republican victory that seems increasingly unlikely he can deliver.
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As pain at the pump continues for all Americans, not only those vocationally dependent on diesel, we assess that the program announcement will not meaningfully swing competitive states like Kansas toward Trump. The challenge in those states is winning back voters who have been disillusioned with the GOP, and it is unlikely a potential bailout will outweigh the administration’s other policies in those voters’ minds.

Democratic midterm sweep would bring limited policy changes. Democrats taking both chambers of Congress in the midterms (60% odds) would limit the legislative agenda in the next Congress, but would not force a major change in policy direction from President Donald Trump's administration.

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With the passage of last year’s reconciliation bill, Congress has largely fulfilled its role in Trump’s agenda. While Democratic control of either chamber would end any hopes of another party-line package in 2027, the dynamic next year would look only somewhat different from 2026, as bipartisan cooperation would still be required on any appropriations or substantive bills to be sent to the president for his signature.

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Moderate fiscal expansion is likely if Democrats win at least one chamber, while the risks of market-disruptive brinksmanship on the debt limit are very limited, given Democrats' historical unwillingness to seek leverage from the issue.

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Investigations and impeachment would be a major focus, with key committees probing the business dealings of figures in or close to the administration, but these would provide little leverage in the absence of any serious threat of removal from office. Impeachment attempts are more likely to target unpopular administration officials than Trump himself.

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For more, please see Democratic midterm sweep would bring limited changes in policy direction , 20 October 2026.

Netanyahu's plans won't lead to pre-midterm escalation. Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu reportedly planned on resuming the war with Iran two weeks ago, before he was talked down by Trump. We do not see this as increasing the odds of pre-midterm escalation, and our expectation of the conflict's resumption after the elections (65% odds) is unchanged.

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Trump has been consistently against resuming the conflict before the midterms because of the political consequences of such a move. Netanyahu’s opinion won’t change that, as demonstrated by the fact that Trump was able to restrain him.

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Structural factors do point to medium-term escalation, though. Negotiations have stalled, and Iranian attacks on shipping risk disrupting energy markets enough to make the status quo untenable for the US. (Please see Hormuz attacks likely to compel US escalation after midterms , 15 October 2026.)

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Escalation likely will not occur until the Roosevelt carrier strike group, currently en route to the Middle East, arrives in theater in November, which would make it the third deployed in the region. We view this overlap period as a material precondition for escalation; the three carriers’ presence will provide additional operational offensive and defensive capability to the US, which may be required to alter the status quo.

Quote of the Day

"You talk so much about my president, President Trump, being a humanitarian. You are a humanitarian also, sir. And I salute that. I commend you." - Special Envoy for Peace Missions Steve Witkoff speaking to Russian President Vladimir Putin in Moscow yesterday after Putin released an American that had been captured in Ukraine. Russia is looking to capitalize on a period of deteriorating US-Ukraine relations, with the hostage release—and promises to consider future rounds of negotiations with the US and Ukraine—being a low-cost way to do so.

On the Radar

30-31 October: G20 Foreign Ministers' meeting

3 November: National midterm elections

9 November: Congress returns from recess

18-19 November: APEC leaders meeting in China

11 December: Government funding runs out

14-15 December: G20 summit in Florida

10 January: US-China tariff truce expires

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